NOVA SCHOOL OF SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

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Too Much Information vs Just Enough Information in Videogame Shops

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Lab Assignment 1

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1. Introduction

User interface (UI) design is important in videogames because it affects how easily players can understand information and make decisions. A good interface presents the information players need without overwhelming them with unnecessary detail.
The document presents a bad example, in this case, **too much information** in a videogame shop, and a good example, **just enough information** that doesn't overwhelm the player.

2. Escape from Tarkov – Trader Interface (Bad Example)

In Escape from Tarkov, the **Trader Interface** allows the player to buy, sell and barter items, mainly equipment, weapons and other resources. It serves as an important part of the game, since it's fundamental for understanding the game's progression and economy system.

Since there are multiple traders, understanding what each trader has, can accept as a trade and the big number of items at the same time can overwhelm the player, especially someone who is not used to it.

It's true that the interface allows for multiple features, however, its presentation and complexity can make the shopping experience unnecessarily demanding with a large learning curve.

Example: A Trader Interface



Design strengths

- **Detailed item information**: Players can inspect items and understand their specifications. The trades clearly show the amount of each item on the exchange.
- **Inventory and exchange**: In the interactions, you can easily tell which inventory of items belongs to the trader and what belongs to the player, with Stash being your personal stash.
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Design Weaknesses:

- **Large information:** information is densely presented, not just on the item selection, but also on everything an item can do, and will sometimes display information that is irrelevant to the transaction.
- **Large Inventories**: If both the trader and the player have a lot of items, it will very easily become overwhelming with the number of selectable items.
- **Multiple currencies and barter**: many currencies, like roubles, dollars, euros, and in-universe coins and even the ability to barter will confuse players. The roubles are the main currency and are used on the trades, but having multiple can lead players to think they can use it on the trades.
- **Complex decisions**: due to the nature of the game, each interaction requires careful reading of descriptions and stats for comparison, which takes time.

Why this design doesn't work and why it was designed this way

The trader interface showcases a big example of too much information in a single screen. There are numerous item icons, and each item comes with a price, quantity, description, purchasing requirements and the stats of said item.
On top of that, due to the game's mechanics and design choice, the player needs to sometimes barter instead of just straight buying it, which adds more steps to a transaction. The individual trader shops have a more limited browsing experience, and players can browse the trader's available inventory, but they don't have the same extensive filtering tools as the Flea Market (another interface inside the game).

Since the game focuses on realism, I believe it was designed to simulate the closest it can get to a survival and resource management reality. The game adds depth to the system to achieve this realism, by adding bartering, for example. A real-life economy system of this caliber would imply a huge selection of information, on top of the progression of having to learn each individual trader.

Improvements could include categorization of items, filtering to only show what you can trade or not, and the usage of progressive disclosure to hide advanced information until the player needs it, like name, icon, price and availability, then later can introduce stats and additional information. Set for a simpler exchange system that doesn't include currency as items and bartering to be a different thing outside of the buying and selling of items.

3. Hades – Well of Charon (Good Example)

In Hades, the **Well of Charon** presents items that players can purchase during a run. The shop interface displays a limited selection of available items and communicates their costs, allowing players to consider what they can afford and what might help them progress.
Compared with an interface that presents extensive item statistics all at once, this shop focuses attention on the immediate decision.
The player does not need to navigate a large catalogue of every possible item to make this choice. The limited selection makes the options easier to scan and helps the player compare the available purchases quickly.

Example: Well of Charon Shop



Design Strengths:

- **Minimal Information:** the description of the items, what they do, and their price is kept to a minimum;
- **Focused choice on Items:** there's a very small selection of items at a time, placing constraints on the player's decision.
- **Simple currency:** the items can be exchanged through a simple currency system and nothing else.
- **Lower visual load:** Players can scan the available options without reading a long list of attributes for every item.
- **Easy objective comparison:** The player can consider the benefit of an item against its cost, also allowing for a quick flow of decision.

Design Weaknesses:

- **Limited information:** Item descriptions are brief and may not explain the full impact of an upgrade.
- **Limited comparison:** There is little support for comparing items directly before purchasing.
- **Small selection:** The limited number of options can reduce player choice.

Why this design works

The Well of Charon demonstrates how a shop can provide enough information for a specific task without displaying every possible detail at once. Players can identify the available choices, check their prices, and decide how to spend their resources.
This approach is especially appropriate in a fast-paced roguelike, where players make many decisions during a run and need to return to gameplay quickly.